

Dvar Torah Outline — Tehillim (Perek 115–116) in Maharal: “השמים שמים לה’ Berachah as Accessing Hashem’s Hashpa’ah, and Why Hashem Listens to Tefillah

Abstract

This dvar Torah (learning Maharal on Tehillim) develops two linked themes: (1) how “ownership” of the world depends on whether we relate to reality through דין (strict justice) or through Hashem’s הטבה (bestowing goodness), and how a ברכת הנהנין is the act that places us into the latter register; and (2) why praising Hashem is rooted in human existence itself, such that death diminishes “הלל,” while added ברכה increases our capacity to praise. The shiur then transitions to “אהבתי כי ישמע ה’,” explaining Chazal’s reading that our experience of Hashem hearing tefillah reveals that we are “beloved,” and concluding with a Maharal framework: since all existence is מושפע from Hashem, it is fitting that He “completes” that existence by answering חסרונות through tefillah—most essentially for Israel, the primary purpose of creation.

I. Framing: “השמים שמים לה’ — Hashem as “הטוב והמשפיע הטוב”

A. Starting point in the perek

- “הַשָּׁמַיִם שָׁמַיִם לַה’ וְהָאָרֶץ נָתַן לִבְנֵי אָדָם” (“The heavens are heavens to Hashem, and the earth He gave to mankind.”)
- Maharal’s thesis:
 - Hashem is הטוב (good) and המשפיע הטוב (the One who bestows goodness).
 - The “giving of the land” is an expression of הטבה—not a human right, but Divine giving.

B. Connection hinted: Birkat HaMazon / “ברכת הארץ”

- The shiur notes a broader Maharal theme (to cross-reference) about why gratitude centers on הארץ (the land) as the quintessential “gift.”

II. The Gemara's contradiction: "לה' הארץ" vs. "ומלואה" vs. "והארץ נתן לבני אדם"

A. The contradiction as posed by Chazal

- "לה' הארץ ומלואה" ("To Hashem belongs the earth and its fullness.")
- "ה'שמים שמים לה' והארץ נתן לבני אדם" ("...and the earth He gave to mankind.")
- Question: Is the world "Hashem's" or "man's"?

B. Chazal's resolution: Berachah changes the status

- "לא קשיא: כִּאֲנִי קִדְּם בְּרַכָּה, כִּאֲנִי לְאַחַר בְּרַכָּה."
 - Before a ברכה, it is "Hashem's"; after, it becomes available to האדם.

C. The conceptual problem Maharal addresses

- Two difficulties raised in the shiur:
 1. **How can a human act (berachah) change "ownership"?**
 2. If Hashem "gave" the earth, why does it require repeated "permission" each time?
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III. Maharal's model: Two concurrent "registers" of reality — הטבה vs. דין

A. דין: by strict justice, a created being owns nothing

- Key Maharal claim:
 - "בוודאי הכל הוא לקדוש ברוך הוא ואין לבריה דבר מצד הדין ומשפט."
 - Since Hashem is Creator, from דין/משפט we have no intrinsic claim.

B. הטבה / חסד: Hashem gives, because He is "ברוך" and "משפיע"

- The only reason humans can "have" anything:
 - "רק בשביל שהוא יתברך מבורך ובשל כך משפיע לנמצאים."
- The world being "given" is not a legal entitlement but a reality of Hashem's goodness.

C. What a berachah does (not a title-transfer, but a perspective shift)

- The shiur's formulation:
 - Reality doesn't toggle back and forth; **both layers are always true**.
 - A berachah is the act of stepping into the "hashpa'ah" register:
 - Recognizing Hashem as source of blessing → receiving **רשות** to partake.
- Without that recognition, taking from the world is "theft":
 - If one lives only in the דין framework while taking, he acts as if entitled where he has no right.

D. Addressing "נתן" as permanent giving

- The challenge:
 - "**והארץ נתן לבני אדם**" sounds permanent ("He gave it"), not conditional access.
- Resolution in the shiur's language:
 - The "gift" is fully real and not revoked—but it is experienced only when we inhabit the נכון perspective:
 - When we acknowledge "this is a bestowed טוב," it is ours to use.
 - When we revert to "it's mine by right," we collapse back into דין, where we have nothing.

E. Practical upshot: Why so many berachos?

- Because benefiting from the world requires repeatedly:
 - re-entering the consciousness of הטבה,
 - not treating existence as entitlement.

IV. Returning to Hallel's flow: Why this pasuk belongs here

A. The perek's broader arc: "ה' זכרנו יברך"

- The shiur locates this inside the theme of **Hashem increasing blessing** for those דבוק to Him.
 - :fits because it reveals "השמים שמים לה'..."
 - Hashem is fundamentally a **giver**, not "stingy,"
 - and His giving is an expression of His being **בורך**.
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V. “לא המתים יהללו קה” — Praise is rooted in existence (מציאות)

A. The pasuk and its claim

- “לא המתים יהללו קה ולא כל ירדי דומה.”
(“The dead will not praise Hashem, nor all who descend to silence.”)

B. Maharal’s definition: “הלל” emerges from being (not only from speech)

- Central idea:
 - “כי ההילול הוא... מצד המציאות שיש לנבראים מורה על הממציא.”
 - The very fact that we exist testifies to the Creator.
 - Additional praise (speech, song, action) intensifies it, but **the root is מציאות**.

C. Death as loss of the primary vehicle of praise

- Those no longer “in existence” cannot provide this testimony.
- The shiur notes the well-known counterpoint:
 - “צדיקים אפילו במיתתם קרוים חיים” (some level of “life” persists),
 - and **תחיית המתים** restores existence, enabling fuller שירה.
 - (Alluded support: “אז ישיר” read as future-facing song.)

D. Why increased blessing increases praise

- “ואנחנו שקיבלנו הברכה נברך קה”
 - More ברכה → more שלמות → more מציאות → greater capacity to reveal Hashem’s goodness.
 - Therefore: **enhanced existence** yields **enhanced הלל**.
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VI. Transition to the next perek: “אהבתי כי” (derash vs. peshat) “שמע ה’ את קולי תחנוני”

A. The textual tension noticed in the shiur

- “אהבתי כי ישמע ה’ את קולי תחנוני.”
(“I loved, for Hashem will hear my voice, my supplications.”)
- Observed difficulty:
 - The mixture of **past tense** and **future** (“אהבתי”) (“ישמע”).

B. Gemara (Pesachim): Knesset Yisrael speaks as “beloved,” not “loving”

- דרשה:
 - “אימתי אני אהובה לפניך? בזמן שאתה שומע קול תחנוני.”
 - is read as “אֶהְבֶּתִי” “When am I loved? When You hear my pleas.

C. Supporting line: “דלותי ולי יהושיע”

- “דלותי ולי יהושיע.”
(“I was brought low, and He saved me.”)
 - Derash:
 - Even if I’m “poor in mitzvot,” salvation is still fitting.
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VII. Maharal’s explanation of the derash: reciprocity reveals Divine love

A. Why peshat alone feels “פשיטא”

- Maharal’s question:
 - If the verse means “I love it when Hashem hears me,” that’s obvious:
 - Everyone loves being heard in distress.
- Therefore, the pasuk must be teaching something deeper.

B. The deeper point: If I feel love, it indicates I am being loved

- Maharal’s move:
 - **If Hashem’s action awakens love in me, that implies a present relationship of love from Him to me.**
 - The shiur’s framing:
 - We can’t “see” Hashem’s love directly,
 - but when we experience Hashem listening and responding, love is **revealed** (not merely theoretically true).
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VIII. Midrash: “אין אזנים של מעלה כרויות אלא לי” Hashem’s “ears” are opened to — “בלבד” Israel

A. The Midrashic phrase and its meaning

- “אין אזנים של מעלה כרויות אלא לי בלבד”
 - “The ears Above are ‘hollowed/opened’ only for me.”
- Clarification of כרויות:
 - understood as “hollowed out/opened” to receive hearing (supported by Rashi’s sense).

B. Supporting pesukim cited

- “חֲטָאת וְעוֹלָה לֹא חָפְצְתָּ; אֲזָנִים כָּרִיתָ לִי”
 (“Sin-offering and burnt-offering You did not desire; ears You opened/hollowed for me.”)
 - “הִט אָזְנוֹךָ וּשְׁמַע”
 (“Incline Your ear and hear.”)
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IX. Why tefillah is “fitting”: Existence as hashpa’ah implies completion through answering חסרון

A. The metaphysical claim

- “שהנמצאים הם מושפעים מאתו.”
 - All beings are “influenced/bestowed” from Hashem.

B. From creation to completion

- Maharal’s logic:
 - If Hashem gives existence, it is appropriate He also “completes” it:
 - “ראוי שיקבל תפלתם להשלים חסרונם.”
 - Tefillah = articulation of lack; answering = השלמה (completion).

C. Why Israel specifically (primary creation → primary listening)

- Conclusion:
 - **Israel are “בעצם ובראשונה”** in creation’s purpose.
 - Other creations are **טפלים לישראל**, made to facilitate Israel’s avodah:
 - **“ולא ברא כל העולם אלא לשמש את ישראל.”**
 - לכן:
 - **“ראוי שיהיה משלים חסרונם בראשונה ובעצם.”**
 - Hashem’s “ears” are primarily “open” to Israel’s tefillah.
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X. In Summary

- The contradiction between “לה’ הארץ ומלואה” and “והארץ נתן לבני אדם” is resolved by Maharal as **two simultaneous layers** הטבה and (no human entitlement) דין : (Hashem’s generous giving).
- A **ברכת הנהיג** is the repeated act of entering the consciousness of “hashpa’ah,” transforming taking-from-the-world into permitted receiving.
- teaches that the deepest praise of Hashem is **“לא המתים יהללו קה”** **itsself** **מציאות**; more blessing means more wholeness and therefore more capacity for הלל.
- is read by Chazal as “אהבתי כי ישמע ה’” When Hashem hears our תחנונים, we are revealed as אהובים—and since existence flows from Hashem, answering tefillah is the completion of the very existence He bestows, most essentially for Israel.